Q. What were the challenges in becoming an idol in Korea?
I was not ready for what was waiting for me here. I remember I landed late at night on October 22, 2022, and the next day I went to the practice room and learnt choreography. Next day, I met a producer and had to sing a song in front of lots of people. I was not doing well initially. I was scared, stressed and cried almost every day. I'd practise alone in the kitchen in front of a mirror. It was a whole new world and I had to catch up to others' level in a very short time.

Q. It's been over two years since you joined X:IN. Have you adapted to the Korean culture, lifestyle and work regimen?
When I first arrived, I felt very alienated. I didn't know the language and didn't know anybody. The culture was new too. But now I have gotten used to the lifestyle and food and can speak Korean comfortably. The idol culture is very intense. There is literally no me-time. I like how unpredictable and busy it is.

Q. As one of the few success stories from India, what does it take to become a K-Pop idol?
Courage and determination. It's not like once you are in, you are always in. They can eliminate you from the company. Your survival instinct has to be strong.

—SS

A WEEK-LONG TRIP TO KOREA COSTS UP TO RS 4 LAKH, BUT FROM 122,771 IN 2023, INDIANS WHO DID THE KOREA CIRCUIT ROSE TO 176,668 IN 2024

FANDOM CENTRAL

The Trend

K-Pop dance group from Arunachal Pradesh

Thanks to his K-Pop-crazy elder sisters, Arunachal Pradesh's Aku Bengia was introduced to bands like BigBang, BTS and Super Junior. Inspired by their YouTube videos and those of Stray Kids and Seventeen, he formed a dance group called The Trend with the sole purpose of winning the annual All-India K-Pop contest organised by the Korean Cultural Centre India. The Trend follows the stylish, spirited and synchronised choreography synonymous with the genre. "K-Pop dancing is a complete package of entertainment—there's drama and each member gets to be in spotlight," says Likha Tatam, one of its seven members. After finishing runner-up in two back-to-back editions of the contest, The Trend finally accomplished their dream last year of winning the title in the dance category with a routine set to Stray Kids's 'God's Menu'. The prize included a five-day trip to Seoul, their very first time abroad. "Belonging from such an interior state, it was a proud moment. We could set an example to kids here and show that by being persistent and disciplined you can achieve your dream," says Aku. The group has participated in the TV show *Dance Plus*, toured across Arunachal Pradesh and recently set up a dance studio in Itanagar. Next up is singing like their idols.

—SS

